

OCR Christianity possible exam questions

These questions are taken directly from the wording of the specification, meaning they could all potentially appear in the exam. They are roughly sorted into easy, medium and hard.

Augustine on Human Nature

Easy

Are Augustine's teachings on a historical Fall and Original Sin wrong?

Assess Augustine's teaching on human nature

Medium

Are Augustine's teachings on the historical Fall correct?

'Augustine's views on Original Sin are false' – How far do you agree?

Is Augustine correct that humans can never be morally good?

Is Augustine's view of human nature pessimistic or optimistic?

Is Original Sin the explanation of human sin and social corruption?

'There is nothing we can do to deserve God's grace' – Discuss.

"Humans cannot be good because of sin." – Discuss.

Hard

'There is no distinctive human nature' – Discuss.

Assess Augustine's interpretation of Genesis

How convincing is Augustine's view of God's grace?

"Only God's generous love can enable humans to reach the *Summum bonum*" – Discuss.

How convincing is Augustine's views on the difference between human

relationships before and after the fall?

Assess Augustine's views on the causes of corruption in societies

Very Hard

"[Human relationships pre-fall / Human relationships post-fall / Original sin / Grace] is the most important part of Augustine's theory of human nature

How convincing are Augustine's views on the *Summum bonum*?

Critically assess Augustine's views on the effects of original sin on societies.

Analyse Genesis chapter 3

"The idea that original sin is passed on through sex is outdated" – Discuss

"The fall was not a historical event" – Discuss

Death and the afterlife

Easy

Does God's judgment take place immediately after death or at the end of time?

Is heaven a place/state/symbol

Is hell a place/state/symbol

Who goes to heaven?

Medium

Is heaven the transformation and perfection of the whole of creation?

Is purgatory a place/state/symbol

Is purgatory a state through which everyone goes?

Are heaven and hell eternal?

Assess limited election

'Everyone goes to heaven' – Discuss.

Is election unlimited?

Are all people called to salvation?

Analyse election

“The idea of the afterlife is just about our spiritual and moral life on earth” –

Discuss

Does a literal heaven make more sense than a literal hell?

Hard

Is hell eternal?

Is heaven eternal?

What does the parable of the sheep and the goats suggest about the afterlife?

Critically assess the implications of the sheep and the goats parable.

What should we conclude from Jesus’ parable on final judgement?

Knowledge of God’s existence

Easy

Can God be known through reason alone?

Is faith sufficient for belief in God?

Assess the possibility of natural knowledge of God’s existence.

Assess whether revealed knowledge of God’s existence is the only valid type.

“Knowledge of God is only possible through faith” – Discuss

Medium

Assess whether the Fall completely removed all natural human knowledge of God

Is faith in God’s revelation in Jesus required to know God?

‘Human sin and finitude prevents natural knowledge of God’ – Discuss.

Can God be known through his creation?

Does God’s creation reveal his beauty, goodness, design and purpose?

Is the Bible the best method for knowing God?

What role does grace play in our knowledge of God?

Hard

“The order of creation is more convincing natural theology than the sensus divinitatis” – Discuss

What is the human intellect capable by itself of discovering about God?

“Humans have no reliable inbuilt capacity to know God” – Discuss

Is the Bible the only available method for knowing God?

To what degree can sinful and finite human minds know God?

Is knowledge of God fully realised by the person of Jesus Christ?

Very Hard

Is natural knowledge of God the same as revealed knowledge?

Is belief in God’s existence sufficient to put one’s trust in him?

Is being made in God’s image relevant to how humans can know God?

Does the life of the Church enable knowledge of God?

“Without the holy spirit, no knowledge of God would be possible” – Discuss

“God is known through beauty” – Discuss

The person of Jesus Christ

Easy

Was Jesus only a teacher of wisdom?

Was Jesus more than a political liberator?

Was Jesus the Son of God?

Who was Jesus?

Medium

Was God’s relationship with Jesus very special or truly unique?

“Jesus was truly unique” – Discuss

What do Jesus’ teachings on repentance and forgiveness tell us about who he was?

“Jesus’ teachings on inner purity and moral motivation show that he was a teacher of wisdom” – Discuss.

Can Jesus’ authority be understood exclusively as the Son of God?

Is 'divine' the best description of Jesus?

Is Jesus' teachings of wisdom the most important thing about him?

Hard

Did Jesus think he was divine?

Does Jesus' resurrection show that Jesus was the Son of God?

"Jesus' miracles show that he was divine" – Discuss.

"Jesus' is most defined by his challenge to political authority" – Discuss.

"Jesus' knowledge of God expresses his divinity" – Discuss.

Are Jesus' miracles the best evidence for his divinity?

Is Jesus better described as a liberator or a teacher of wisdom?

Is Jesus more defined by his teachings on moral motivation than by his challenge to religious authority?

Very Hard

Did Jesus challenge political authority more than religious authority?

"Mark 6:47-52 (walking on water) shows that Jesus is the son of God" – Discuss.

Assess the implications for the person of Jesus of John 9:1-41 (Healing blind man)

Does Matthew 5:17-48 (sermon on the mount) show that Jesus is only a teacher of wisdom?

Does Matthew Luke 15:11-32 (Parable of lost Son) show that Jesus is only a teacher of wisdom?

"Jesus was a liberator as shown in Mark 5-24:34" (12-year Menstruating woman that Jesus healed) – Discuss.

What does Luke 10:25-37 (The good Samaritan) tell us about Jesus?

Christian moral principles

Easy

Is the principle of love sufficient to live a good life?

Is the Bible a comprehensive moral guide?

‘Christian ethics should combine the Bible, Church and reason’ – How far do you agree?

Medium

Does the Bible reveal God’s will?

What is the implication for Christian ethics of Jesus’ command to love?

Critically compare the view of the Bible having the only authority with it having equal authority to Church teachings.

Critically compare agape with the bible as sources of Christian moral principles.

In Christian ethics, is human reason better employed in the application of agape or in combination with the bible and church?

Does focusing on the Bible alone and excluding reason and church teaching improve Christian ethics?

Hard

Is Christian ethics distinctive?

Are Christian ethics personal or communal?

“The Bible reveals God’s will, so only biblical ethical commands must be followed” – Discuss.

“Jesus’ only command was to love” – Discuss.

“Human reason must work with the bible and Church teaching, not only in applying *agape*” – Discuss.

“Reason should play no role in Christian ethical practices” – Discuss.

Christian moral action

Easy

Does Bonhoeffer put too much emphasis on suffering?

Assess Bonhoeffer’s teaching on the relationship of Church and State

‘Bonhoeffer’s views on the cost of discipleship are too extreme’ – How far do you agree?

Medium

Is it possible always to know God’s will?

How relevant is Bonhoeffer’s theology today?

Should Christians practise civil disobedience?

“Bonhoeffer was overall not a good role model for Christians” – Discuss.

To what degree does Christian ethics require sacrifice and suffering?

Critically assess the implications of Bonhoeffer’s role in the Confessing Church and Finkenwalde.

What can Christians learn from the Confessing Church?

How should Christians balance their duty to God with their duty to the state?

Hard

Assess Bonhoeffer’s views on the role of the Church.

How should a Christian think about the relation between duty of God and duty to the state?

“Christians should follow Bonhoeffer’s teachings on solidarity” – Discuss.

Assess Bonhoeffer’s teaching on ethics as action.

“Bonhoeffer’s views on cheap and costly grace is the most important part of his theology” – Discuss.

What is the cost of discipleship?

What limitations should Christians have regarding civil disobedience?

Very Hard:

“[Duty to God vs the state / The Church as community & spiritual discipline / The cost of discipleship] is the most important part of Bonhoeffer’s theology” – Discuss

“Bonhoeffer’s teachings conflict with his example” – Discuss

“There’s nothing we can learn from Bonhoeffer’s teachings that we can’t learn

from his life and example” – Discuss

How important is it for the Church to be a source of spiritual discipline?

Religious pluralism and theology

Easy

Assess exclusivism

Assess inclusivism

‘Pluralism is true’ – Do you agree?

If Christ is the ‘truth’ can there be any other means of salvation?

‘All good people will be saved’ – Discuss.

Are there multiple equal paths to salvation?

Is Christianity the one path or merely one path to salvation?

‘Christianity fully offers the means of salvation’ – How far do you agree?

Medium

Does theological pluralism undermine central Christian beliefs?

Would a loving God ultimately deny any human being salvation?

Is Christianity the normative means of salvation?

What are the implications of Christ being the ‘truth’?

Critically compare exclusivism with inclusivism

Critically compare exclusivism with Pluralism

Critically compare inclusivism with Pluralism

Hard

“The doctrine of anonymous Christians is false’ – Discuss.

Has contemporary exclusivist theology improved on traditional exclusivism?

“Since Christ said he is the truth, it’s incoherent of pluralism to say Christianity is only one possible path” – Discuss

“Christianity is either true or false – it cannot be merely one equal path of many” –

Discuss

Very Hard

“Inclusivism is just a stepping stone to pluralism” – Discuss

“The reasons to accept inclusivism over exclusivism are a slippery slope to pluralism” – Discuss

Evaluate whether the Christ being the truth is a central belief of Christianity.

Religious pluralism and society

Easy

Has inter-faith dialogue contributed practically towards social cohesion?

Assess the methods and aims of the scriptural reasoning movement

Should Christian communities seek to convert people from other faiths?

Should Christians have a mission to those of no faith?

“Inter-faith dialogue is a waste of time” – Discuss.

Medium

Does mutual study and interpretation of different religions’ sacred literature benefit society?

“Christians should not study the sacred texts of other religions” – Discuss.

‘Scriptural reasoning relativizes religious belief’ – Discuss.

How should Christians respond to inter-faith dialogue?

How should Christians respond to the development of contemporary multi-faith societies?

Does the transition into multifaith society require religions to develop new ways of thinking about other religions?

“Interfaith dialogue is more important the conversion” – Discuss

Hard

Have Christian communities responded well to the challenge of encounters with other faiths?

How might understanding of different and conflicting religious truth claims be promoted?

How successful is the Catholic approach to other faiths?

“The Church of England’s approach to other faiths fails to enable social cohesion” – Discuss.

Analyse the views expressed in ‘*Redemptoris Missio*’.

Critically compare the Catholic Church with the Church of England on their

approaches to the challenge of other faiths

Assess the views expressed in the Church of England's '*Sharing the Gospel of Salvation*'.

Critically compare *Redemptoris Missio* with *Sharing the Gospel of Salvation*.

Gender and society

Easy

Should official Christian teaching resist current secular views of gender?

Have secular views of gender equality undermined Christian gender roles?

Assess Christian teaching on the roles of men and women in the family and society.

How successful have Christian responses to secular views about gender been?

Medium

Is motherhood liberating or restricting?

'Christian teaching on the gender roles in the family and society is sexist' – How far do you agree?

'Traditional Christian views on gender roles are more successful than secular views' – Discuss.

Critically assess the views expressed in *Mulieris Dignitatem*.

Are Christian challenges to changing attitudes about gender convincing?

"Christian thought and practice have been undermined by contemporary secular views on gender roles" – Discuss.

"Christian gender roles are anti-woman" – Discuss

To what degree should Christians accept different types of family?

Are changing attitudes towards the idea of 'family' progressing in the right direction?

"The sooner we leave Christian views on gender in the past the better for everyone" – Discuss.

Hard

Is the idea of family entirely culturally determined?

Has Christianity successfully adapted to changing views on family and gender?

“Christianity should accept different types of family than the traditional” –

Discuss.

“Challenging Christian practice regarding gender roles has not had any effect” –

Discuss.

“Mulieris Dignitatem” has not improved on Ephesians 5:22” – Discuss

Gender and theology

Easy

Is Christianity essentially sexist?

What are the implications of gender for the Christian idea of God?

Evaluate Ruether’s views on gender.

Evaluate Daly’s views on gender.

Critically compare Ruether and Daly’s feminist theologies.

Critically compare Ruether and Daly’s attitude towards Christianity.

Should Christianity be changed or abandoned?

Medium

‘A male saviour cannot save women’ – Discuss.

Is Ruether or Daly more convincing regarding sexism and patriarchy in Christianity

‘Only women can develop a genuine spirituality’- Discuss.

Can the Christian God be presented in female terms?

‘If God is male, then the male is God’ – Discuss.

Is the Unholy trinity the real trinity of Christianity?

Critically assess Ruether’s view of Jesus.

Assess Ruether’s views on the implications for salvation of the maleness of Christ.

“Viewing Jesus as the incarnation of wisdom cannot justify Ruether’s feminist

theology” – Discuss.

To what degree is it accurate to describe Christianity as sexist?

Critically assess feminist reinterpretations of God.

Analyse Daly’s ‘unholy trinity’.

Is presenting God in female terms the right direction for Christianity?

Hard

Is Ruether or Daly more convincing regarding sexism and patriarchy in mainstream Churches

Critically compare Ruether and Daly’s views on the maleness of Christ and God.

What are the implications of Jesus’ challenge to the male warrior-messiah expectation?

“The female wisdom principle has nothing to do with the Christian God” – Discuss.

“True spirituality is found by women in nature” – Discuss

Very Hard

“[Gender / The Christian idea of God / The maleness of Christ / Jesus’ challenge to the messiah-warrior expectation / God as the female wisdom principle / Jesus as the incarnation of wisdom] is the most important part of Ruether’s feminist theology” – Discuss

“[Gender / The Christian idea of God / “If God is male then the male is God” / The unholy trinity / Spirituality experienced through nature] is the most important part of Daly’s feminist theology” – Discuss

The Challenge of Secularism

Easy

Does Christianity cause personal and social problems?

Should Christianity be a significant contributor to society's culture and values?

'Christianity is infantile, repressive and causes conflict' – How far do you agree?

Medium

Are spiritual values just human values?

If we get rid of religion will there be no basis for morality?

'Christianity significantly defines today's culture and values' – Discuss

Would society be happier without Christianity?

Is Christianity the result of wish fulfilment?

Would there be less conflict without Christianity?

"Christianity was useful once but we'd be better off without it now" – Discuss.

Hard

Can Christianity learn and develop from secularism?

Assess the views and goals of secular humanism

Is Christian belief a personal or public matter?

'Christianity has no place in education or schools' – Discuss.

'Society has improved because religion was divorced from political power' – How far do you agree?

Critically compare Freud and Dawkins on secularisation.

"Christian belief is just personal" – Discuss

"Secular humanism is insufficient to replace religion" – Discuss.

Is humanity without religion a liberating or terrifying thought?

Very Hard

Could Christianity realistically be confined to private life?

Should Christianity respect the distinction between public and private life?
“Secular humanism couldn’t have developed without Christianity” – Discuss

Liberation Theology and Marx

Easy

Should Christian theology engage with atheist secular ideologies?
Is it right for Christians to prioritise one group over another?
‘Christians have nothing to learn from Marx’ – How far do you agree?
Should Christians have a preferential option for the poor?
How should Christians tackle the issue of social sin?

Medium

Does Christianity tackle social issues more effectively than Marxism?
How appropriate is liberation theology’s use of Marx to analyse social sin?
Should the Church concern itself with ‘structural’ causes of social sin?
‘The Gospel demands that Christians must give priority to the poor’ – Discuss.
‘Christianity has nothing to say about capitalism’ – Discuss.
“Marx’s teaching on alienation and exploitation has no relevance for Christianity”
– Discuss.
How important in Christianity is solidarity with the poor?
Should Christians criticise capitalism?
What do Christians have to learn from Marx’s concepts of alienation and exploitation?

Hard

Has liberation theology engaged with Marxism fully enough?

Should orthopraxis occur before orthodoxy?

“Capitalism and institutions are the cause of social sin” – Discuss.

How should Christians deal with economic dehumanisation and the treatment of people as objects?

“Acting in solidarity with the poor should be the foundation of the Christian mission” – Discuss.

Very Hard

“[Marx on alienation & exploitation / use of Marx to analyse capitalism & institutions / Liberation theology’s views on the preferential option for the poor / The gospel’s support for solidarity with the poor / placing orthodoxy before orthopraxis] is the most important part of liberation theology” – Discuss